



Monitoring, Evaluation, Learning and Impact
Assessment (MELIA) Plan

Better Diets and Nutrition Science Program

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Acronyms and Abbreviations

AABS	Asia-Africa BlueTech Superhighway project
AoW	Area of Work
BCC	behavior change communication
CCU	Country Coordination Unit
ESA	East and Southern Africa
F&V	fruit and vegetables
FAIR	findability, accessibility, interoperability, and reusability
FBDG	food-based dietary guidelines
FRESH	Fruit and Vegetables for Sustainable Healthy Diets
GAP	Good Agricultural Practices
GI	glycemic index
HLO	high-level output
HLPE	High-Level Panel of Experts on Food Security and Nutrition
IA	Impact Area
IAES	Independent Advisory and Evaluation Service
LAC	Latin America and the Caribbean
LMIC	low- and middle-income country
M&E	monitoring and evaluation
MELIA	monitoring, evaluation, learning, and impact assessment
MSME	micro, small and medium enterprise
N4G	Nutrition for Growth Summit
NAP-FST	national action plans for food systems transformation
NGO	non-governmental organization
PNR	perishable nutrient-rich
PORB	Plan of Results and Budget
PRMS	Performance and Results Management System
RCT	randomized controlled trial
RFM	Rethinking Food Markets
SA	South Asia
SAPLING	Sustainable Animal Productivity
SDG	Sustainable Development Goal
SEA	Southeast Asia
SHiFT	Sustainable Healthy Diets through Food Systems Transformation
ToC	theory of change
ToT	training of trainers
UNFSS	United Nations Food Systems Summit
UPF	ultra-processed food
W3	Window 3
WCA	West and Central Africa
WP	Work Package
WUR	Wageningen University and Research
WorldVeg	World Vegetable Center

1. Program overview and results framework

Program overview

Description

Globally, food systems are failing to deliver healthy diets for all in a sustainable and equitable way. Almost three billion people worldwide cannot afford healthy diets. Perishable nutrient-rich (PNR) foods are often unavailable, especially in low- and middle-income countries (LMICs) in Africa and Asia. Urbanization, changes in agri-food systems and the rise of cheap, highly processed, nutrient-poor foods are worsening diets. Climate change, conflict, and economic instability further undermine the provision of sustainable healthy diets to populations in LMICs through food systems, contributing to widespread malnutrition in all its forms – undernutrition, micronutrient deficiencies, obesity, and diet-related non-communicable diseases - and rising health and economic costs.

Better Diets and Nutrition aims to increase the consumption of sustainable healthy diets. Within the new CGIAR Portfolio, this Program challenges traditional ways of thinking about how to transform food systems to improve diets by viewing consumers as the strategic entry point for systemic change, rather than focusing on solutions related to production, technology, and efficiency alone. The Program uses a food systems approach rooted in the High-Level Panel of Experts on Food Security and Nutrition's (HLPE) [food systems framework](#) and addresses five key constraints that shape the healthiness of diets, accessibility, affordability, availability, desirability, and agency, working across the entire food system from consumer to producer. Through research, engagement, and capacity sharing, the research builds evidence for system-wide solutions that overcome these constraints to support governance and drive investments to attain sustainable healthy diets and curb the current unhealthy and harmful megatrends damaging the health of people and the planet.

Over the next six years, the Program will make significant contributions to CGIAR's 2030 targets in the Impact Area (IA) on Nutrition, Health, and Food Security (Nutrition), while contributing to broader efforts on climate, sustainability, livelihoods, and equity. These results will be achieved through partnerships within and beyond the agricultural sector, targeted interventions in national food system pathways, and by leveraging CGIAR's expertise in diets, nutrition, and social science.

Components

Consumers and Food Environments

Area of Work 1 (AoW1) uses mixed-methods research to support government-led efforts to shift consumer behavior and food environments in support of sustainable healthy diets, while also advancing equity, income, food safety, and environmental goals. Generated evidence comes from policy analysis, political economy research, and consumer studies, including pilots and evaluations of solutions such as national food-based dietary guidelines (FBDG), food labeling, taxes, and vendor-focused strategies. AoW1's assessments of dietary intake, its drivers, and food environments help characterize consumption patterns and barriers to change. Scenario modelling and trade-off analyses inform multisector foresight dialogues. The primary entry point in each country is their national action plan for food systems transformation (NAP-FST). The team's close collaborations with government actors involve co-design of technical support, training, and monitoring systems that track transformation processes. This AoW promotes south-south learning, strengthens science-policy interfaces, and facilitates inclusive coalitions to help countries adaptively manage their national food system transitions. *Focus in 2025: Bangladesh, Ethiopia, Ghana, Guatemala, Honduras, Kenya, Tanzania, and Viet Nam.*

Market Systems

AoW2 has three specific research angles aimed at improving market systems for sustainable nutritious foods that are part of a sustainable healthy diet food basket. First, it investigates innovative approaches to reward food quality, reduce food safety risks, lower transaction costs among value chain actors, and minimize food loss and waste. These improvements help increase the availability of sustainable nutritious foods but are insufficient alone to grow markets. Second, it focuses on innovations in finance markets, including insurance and blended finance, to understand which finance actors are willing to invest in new products and design tailored financial solutions that increase investment flows, expanding market availability and affordability. Third, this AoW studies broader macroeconomic issues shaping food availability, including regulations affecting ultra-processed foods (UPF) and the role of international trade in accessing healthier options. Throughout the process, the team uses innovative qualitative and quantitative data collection methods to enhance evidence quality. Research initiated in 2025 will align closely with the NAP-FST in AoW2's countries to ensure alignment with national priorities and maximize policy impact. *Focus in 2025: Bangladesh, Ethiopia, Honduras, India, Kenya, Nigeria, and Uganda.*

End-to-End Approaches

Anchored in a whole-of-diet perspective, AoW3 starts with consumers and understanding their dietary patterns, gaps, excesses, and drivers. The team investigates context- and population-specific barriers—accessibility, affordability, availability, desirability, and agency—that limit intake of PNR foods or lead to their displacement by nutrient-poor options. AoW3 follows an end-to-end approach, the co-location of interconnected solutions from consumers to producers that combine demand generation for fruit and vegetables (F&V), food environment improvements, and supply-side support. The Approach prioritizes co-creation with a range of stakeholders, including community members, ensuring solutions are relevant and tailored to beneficiary needs. Specifically, this AoW focuses on increasing intake of F&V, aquatic foods, and terrestrial animal-source foods while reducing food loss and waste, improving affordability, minimizing environmental harm, supporting livelihoods, and promoting sustainable production and post-harvest practices. Research methods include dietary assessments, household surveys, food environment assessments, studies on food loss and food safety, processing and storage innovation trials, agronomic practices, pricing and demand analyses, willingness-to-pay experiments, impact evaluations, cost-benefit analyses, scenario modeling, and policy research. The evidence generated will be embedded in national processes to support scaling of inclusive, equitable end-to-end solutions. The team's collaboration with governments and platforms like food system alliances enables shared learning, technical support, and capacity sharing. *Focus in 2025: Benin, the Philippines, Sri Lanka, Tanzania, and Uganda.*

Biofortified and Health-Enhancing Staples

AoW4 aims to increase the consumption of biofortified crops, such as the orange-fleshed sweet potato, and health-enhancing crops such as low glycemic index (GI) rice, as part of a food basket supporting sustainable healthy diets. It builds on CGIAR's investments and innovations to improve the nutrient and health enhancing quality of commonly consumed staple crops. AoW4's research agenda, building on understanding consumption patterns and drivers of food choice, generates evidence to influence, develop, and upgrade value chains for biofortified and health-enhancing crops; promote their sustained adoption; and scale nutrient-dense varieties and products to promote consumption by diverse consumers. The aim is to make these improved varieties a market and consumer success. The team's research activities include building the evidence base for new biofortified and health-enhancing crops, developing and determining consumer acceptance of affordable, minimally processed food products using biofortified and health-enhancing crops as ingredients, and understanding and addressing constraints to the

uptake of biofortified and health-enhancing crops and products. Research approaches include efficacy and effectiveness of trials, product development, consumer, and market research, impact evaluations, descriptive studies, and policy analyses and engagement. *Focus in 2025: Bangladesh, Ethiopia, Guatemala, India, Kenya, Malawi, Nigeria, the Philippines, and Uganda.*

NB. This Program will not carry out production-related research, except for AoW3's work on F&V. For AoW3, supply side issues related to aquaculture and livestock science are important and fall under the domain of Sustainable Animal and Aquatic Foods with whom joint work is planned; the [World Vegetable Center](#) (WorldVeg) provides expertise in vegetable production. For AoW4, crop and agronomic science fall under the mandate of Breeding for Tomorrow and Sustainable Farming.

Multisectoral Systems

In response to stakeholder feedback, AoW5 has been reframed to focus on understanding how complementary interventions in LMICs can enhance the positive impact of food system transformation on diets and nutrition. Key areas include social protection programs that improve household purchasing power and empower marginalized groups, as well as institutional catering (e.g., school meals, community kitchens). Nutrition education, behavior change communication, counseling, and gender-focused campaigns addressing roles and norms related to diets are also priorities. These complementary actions help ensure inclusive access and that improved food availability leads to nutritional benefits. The team's research methods include systematic reviews, meta-analyses, large-scale data analysis, and case studies. In the future, AoW5's activities may expand to include implementation research, impact evaluations, and cost-effectiveness studies supported by pooled funding.

Transformative Leadership

AoW6 integrates insights from across the Program and CGIAR Portfolio to accelerate improvements in diets and nutrition. It consolidates evidence, tools, and lessons to inform policy, governance, and coordination at national, regional, and global levels. The work supports cross-country learning and strengthens food systems transformation capacities through strategic engagement and shared knowledge. AoW6 aims to build a cadre of local leaders committed to advancing sustainable healthy diets across diverse contexts. Research methods include evidence synthesis, policy reviews, and governance studies. Complementary activities include leadership development, capacity sharing, and promoting the use of tailored, diet-focused indicators to guide agriculture and food system sectors. By embedding research and learning in global networks, AoW6 ensures that CGIAR's work contributes to broad, systemic change for improved nutrition.

Value proposition

Better Diets and Nutrition delivers system-wide solutions to transform food systems for sustainable healthy diets. With consumers as the entry point, the Program tackles five constraints to sustainable healthy diets — accessibility, affordability, availability, desirability, and agency. Through rigorous, transdisciplinary research and strategic partnerships, it co-generates actionable evidence and builds joint capacities to scale solutions that are grounded in equity, inclusivity, and co-creation. Anchored in the CGIAR Portfolio, the Program accelerates impacts in nutrition, health, and food security while contributing to broader goals on climate, equity, and livelihoods and positions food systems as a critical lever to improve diets and planetary well-being.

Background and context

This Program builds primarily on work of the CGIAR Initiatives including Fruit and Vegetables for Sustainable Healthy Diets (FRESH), Sustainable Healthy Diets through Food Systems Transformation (SHiFT), Rethinking Food Markets (RFM), the Nutrition Impact Platform, and one Work Package (WP) each from Sustainable Animal Productivity (SAPLING) and One Health.

FRESH started by laying a strong foundation both in terms of understanding the relevant challenges, their drivers and possible solutions as well as building robust partnerships and generating buy-in from a range of national and international stakeholders. FRESH conducted extensive reviews, foresight analysis, quantitative and qualitative research to understand the dietary patterns, food environments, post-harvest F&V practices, vegetable farming practices as well as the context specific opportunities and constraints for addressing the identified constraints. Additionally, adaptive trials, rescues, variety trials and multi-location evaluations and other activities related to improving vegetable cultivars and preserving biodiversity were conducted. Lastly, two randomized controlled trials were started in Tanzania and Sri Lanka to test the effectiveness of the end-to-end approach and the additional benefits of adding demand and food environment interventions to supply side interventions. Baselines have been conducted in both countries with Tanzania having had a second round of data collection to assess the impact of the supply side activities in 2024. We plan to continue these studies through the Science Program Phase.

SHiFT started in Ethiopia, Bangladesh, and Viet Nam. SHiFT used quantitative and qualitative methods to understand the determinants of household dietary choices with a focus on adolescents; explored the interface between consumer households and their food environments in urban, peri-urban and rural settings; and began identifying possible solutions (e.g. co-designed food environment interventions based on adolescent aspirations, behavior change approaches, and support for informal vendors and micro, small, and medium enterprises (MSMEs) to improve access to healthy foods) to improve the consumption of sustainable healthy diets. This was complemented by work on the use of foresight modelling and participatory scenarios to explore future pathways.

This Program anticipates deploying pooled resources to deepen AoW 1's work in the SHiFT countries and expand to new countries. In Ethiopia, Bangladesh and Viet Nam, the focus will be on: (i) the design and evaluation of solutions to support sustainable healthy diets at the interface between consumers and their food environments using tools such as labeling, taxation, school feeding programs and behavior change communication (BCC); (ii) policy innovations to strengthen the implementation and governance of NAP-FST activities from the national to subnational scale; and (iii) capacity sharing to build large-scale networks of change agents – including decision-makers, researchers, civil society, implementers, and youth with a common language and skillset for food systems transformation in support of sustainable healthy diets. In new countries (Honduras, Senegal, Guatemala and Benin), this Program anticipates implementing an adapted version of the SHiFT theory of change (ToC) anchored in strong partnerships with NAP-FST convenors from the agriculture and health sectors, policymakers, local civil society, and academic partners.

This work was anchored in deep engagement and capacity sharing with strategic partners – organizations tasked with the design and implementation of NAP-FST in each country – to build common language and understanding in support of sustainable healthy diets.

National action plans

During the [2021 United Nations Food Systems Summit \(UNFSS\)](#), countries presented their visions and commitments for transforming food systems to become more sustainable and contribute to the achievement of the 2030 Agenda and the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). One expected outcome from the 2021 process was a national food systems transformation pathway document for each country. The pathway document articulated the route to achieving the nation's food systems vision and was intended to serve as a point of reference across government and for all stakeholders in the coming years. It was a living document and, unless otherwise stated, not final or endorsed by the government (UN Food Systems Coordination Hub 2023).

The steps following the UNFSS were not prescriptive. However, many countries expressed intentions to develop a national action plan to describe how the food systems transformation pathway would be implemented through a coherent, multisectoral set of actions. The launch of SHiFT in 2022 coincided with this non-linear political process, which is influenced by and reflects sectoral and multisectoral interests linked to food systems policy reform, implementation, and stock taking. As each country's food systems transformation agenda is operationalized and becomes more specific – in some cases this means implementing game changing solutions – it is part of SHiFT's strategy to look for opportunities to provide evidence for solutions that stimulate consumer demand for sustainable healthy diets and the supply of sustainable nutritious foods through MSMEs or other informal actors, in particular.

Country engagement model

As part of the UNFSS, each country nominated a National Food Systems Convenor. Subsequently, the President or Prime Minister appointed certain individuals in government institutions to chair or coordinate the implementation of the national food systems transformation pathway. When SHiFT refers to country engagement, it is these government institutions and the individuals working in those institutions to which SHiFT is initially engaging (during Phase 1, 2022-2024). We refer to them in SHiFT as our Strategic Partners.

SHiFT developed a systematic country engagement model to provide actionable key steps for implementing its approach in each country. The model is centered on strong national partnerships bridging food, agriculture, nutrition, and public health. Following the 2021 UNFSS, countries nominated a Food Systems National Convenor to lead national dialogues on food systems transformation. In Bangladesh, Ethiopia, and Viet Nam, SHiFT engaged directly with the National Convenors, formalizing partnerships through Memoranda of Understanding. In countries where the National Convenors represented only food and agriculture, SHiFT also engaged with the Ministry of Health and embedded nutrition and public health institutions. Collectively, these actors became known as Strategic Partners and were instrumental in integrating SHiFT's research and capacity sharing into national food systems transformation processes.

In each target country, engagement between SHiFT and Strategic Partners was managed by a Country Coordinator, as part of a broader Country Coordination Unit (CCU). The Country Coordinator was a full-time, in-country position hired by a CGIAR Center. The role required strong networking and communication skills, fulfilling two key functions: (1) providing internal coordination across SHiFT WPs, and (2) facilitating ongoing engagement with Strategic Partners. The CCUs served as SHiFT's primary in-country communication hubs, ensuring research findings and technical support reached national decision-makers and that research demands reached CGIAR researchers. The CCUs met quarterly to exchange information, with frequent informal communication to maintain continuous engagement.

Previous pooled funding in the Nutrition Impact Platform to convene, amplify, and build capacity will be carried into AoW6, with new work on testing new knowledge products, methodologies, and engagements (e.g., training modules on food systems transformation, methods to evaluate policy coherence, and engagement models for cross-sectoral collaboration). Working with other AoWs within this Program, and across CGIAR, AoW6 will develop, implement and disseminate knowledge and capacity packages to influence global and regional agendas on food systems transformation, frame research priorities with the donor community and partners, and amplify evidence-based solutions and innovations to broader stakeholders.

RFM initiated research related to quality assurance, efficiency enhancing innovations, inclusive value chain contracting, and financial innovations focusing on value chains for healthy foods in Bangladesh, Ethiopia, Guatemala/Honduras, Nigeria and Uganda, which will be continued as part of this Program's AoW2. The pooled funding will further serve to continue updating the AgIncentives database of food system policy indicators and the global and country model-based scenario analysis to assess impacts and tradeoffs of scaled innovations and reformed policy support. AoW2 will also continue work initiated in One Health on addressing food safety issues and reducing risk exposure in informal value chains, which was conducted in Viet Nam, Ethiopia, and Kenya.

SAPLING implemented its WP2 on "Innovation for safe consumption of livestock-derived foods" in Vietnam and Uganda. There were two main workstreams: (a) designing and piloting a framework (FoodSENSE), drawing on food environment and food system theories to identify the barriers to food and nutrition security and guide prioritization of nutrition related interventions and (b) co-designing social behavior change communication interventions with partners that improve nutrition knowledge and address social norms to demystify consumption of animal source foods by women and children to enhance food choice decisionmaking. An innovative part of the intervention is that the campaigns are tailored to gender. AoW3 plans to: (i) evaluate and refine the framework based on the results from the pilots, explore integration of remote sensed data, and further build capacities of organizations using the toolkit, (ii) build on the social behavior change communication intervention to evaluate its impact and further strengthen the capacities of scaling partners on gender-sensitive nutrition interventions. The focus will shift from livestock keepers to consumers more broadly.

Some work conducted under Accelerated Breeding, Genebanks, and Market Intelligence will inform priorities for research in AoW 4 in terms of supporting the market intelligence effort and strengthening the impact of biofortified and health-enhancing staple foods.

Theory of change

The program ToC is available online at: <https://toc.mel.cgiar.org/toc/567e4617-92b2-462b-a93c-86e3f4ab3239?relatedFlowId=ca63d124-8943-49fc-bc56-95497ef15191>

Challenge statement and high-level changes needed

Current food systems are failing to provide sustainable healthy diets for all. Almost three billion people worldwide cannot afford healthy diets. Shortfalls in the availability of nutrient-rich foods are common, especially in LMICs. Urbanization and changes in agri-food systems are changing people's consumption patterns in favor of cheap, highly processed, nutrient-poor foods. Climate vulnerability, conflict, and economic shocks are exacerbating these challenges to the healthiness of diets and nutrition outcomes. The result is an epidemic of unhealthy diets that contribute to all forms of malnutrition, including undernutrition, micronutrient deficiencies,

obesity, and diet-related noncommunicable diseases, and impose heavy economic costs. Undernutrition alone can cost up to 16% of gross domestic product.

Better Diets and Nutrition is anchored in the HLPE food systems framework. This framework highlights two things where are important to understanding our Program. One, the food environment has a central role in facilitating nutritious, healthy and sustainable consumer food choices and two diets are an important link between food systems and their nutrition and health outcomes ([HLPE 2017](#)). In other words, our Program views food systems transformation as an opportunity to improve diets and nutrition by changing the deeper, system-wide issues that prevent people from being able to eat in ways that are both good for their health and the planet.

We focus on five barriers to sustainable healthy diets:

1. Accessibility. Many cannot regularly and conveniently access diverse, nutritious and safe foods.
2. Affordability. Low incomes and high food prices make healthy diets unaffordable.
3. Availability. Insufficient year-round availability of nutrient-rich foods limits access and raises costs.
4. Desirability. Changing consumption patterns, poor marketing practices, lack of convenience, and other factors deter people from choosing healthy foods.
5. Agency. People need the power and ability to make positive decisions about their food and engage in shaping food system policies.

End of Program 2030 outcomes and assumptions and causal logic, explaining how and why it is expected that outputs will contribute to changes

By 2030, we expect consumers to consume sustainable healthy diets that are accessible, affordable, available, and desirable and have agency to make their own choices. Progress towards this outcome will be measured by two indicators, the percentage of women of reproductive age achieving minimum dietary diversity and the percentage of population who can afford a healthy diet.

Looking beyond 2030, anticipated next-level outcomes include improved population-level nutrition and health indicators; enhanced resilience of food systems to economic, climate, and conflict-related shocks; and more inclusive, equitable food systems that sustain dietary improvements across generations. These outcomes will be made possible by institutionalized national strategies, greater private-sector engagement in nutritious food markets, and a stronger regional and global policy environment for healthy diets.

There are several assumptions behind this goal. Sustainable nutritious foods are produced at sufficient scale to meet population demand, in underserved areas, in particular (**availability**). Food supply chains function efficiently so that perishable nutrient-rich foods reach consumers without excessive loss or cost (**accessibility** and **affordability**). Markets and retailers are willing and able to stock and promote sustainable nutritious food options (**accessibility**). Consumers have sufficient and stable incomes or social protection to afford healthy food options regularly (**affordability**). Consumers are aware of what constitutes a healthy, sustainable diet and trust the sources providing that information (**desirability**). Cultural norms and preferences allow for adoption of more nutritious and sustainable foods (**desirability**). Food choices are not overly constrained by time, availability, or social pressures (**agency**).

In addition, we assume that structural inequalities (gender, rural/urban) are addressed, so all groups can access and benefit from healthy diets. Market innovations and investments are inclusive, rather than deepening existing inequities. Food production remains viable in the face of climate change and environmental degradation. Sustainability measures do not significantly raise costs or limit supply of nutritious foods for low-income consumers.

Our Program will contribute first and foremost to the CGIAR IA on Nutrition in key countries and make meaningful contributions to the other impact areas. We contribute directly through our program and indirectly through our internal support to CGIAR programs and accelerators targeting the IA on Nutrition to achieve the CGIAR target of 3 billion people who do not currently have access to safe and nutritious food.

Two pathways, the target actors, and expected outcomes before 2030

Transforming food systems to address poor diets and malnutrition requires action across many elements of complex systems change. This Program focuses strategically on two key pathways — innovation and policy — that it identifies as the most impactful for achieving sustainable healthy diets and improved nutrition outcomes.

The policy pathway emphasizes government actions (e.g., regulations, taxes, trade policies, subsidies, dietary guidelines) that create conditions that enable food system actors, from consumers to farmers, to adopt new practices that overcome the barriers to sustainable healthy diets. Such actions also create conditions that increase policy coherence, alignment of priorities, and coordination within a country (e.g., across sectoral ministries or levels of government) and across regions to achieve sustainable healthy diets alongside other desired outcomes of food systems transformation, like environmental sustainability and poverty reduction. The target actors along this pathway are policymakers, government ministers, and civil servants. Our contribution is to:

- Support national/sub-national policies to promote sustainable healthy diets
- Engage with NAP-FST and related policy processes
- Engage with NAP-FST and related policy processes
- Encourage integration of biofortified and health-enhancing crops into national strategies

The innovation pathway emphasizes testing technologies or practices (“solutions”) that increase productivity and efficiency along different points of the value chain for sustainable nutritious foods and overcome the barriers to sustainable healthy diets. target actors along this pathway are food system actors: consumers, retailers, processors, traders, and producers. . Engagement with food system actors creates conditions that enable them to use solutions, which reduce post-harvest loss and waste, improve food safety and food quality, increase access to finance, and increase production. Our contribution is to:

- Promote adoption of solutions that increase availability and affordability of sustainable nutritious foods.
- Enhance profitability and incentives to produce sustainable nutritious foods.
- Encourage employment, innovation, and end-to-end system improvements

Capacity sharing, in the language of the CGIAR Capacity Sharing Accelerator, “accelerates the transfer, acquisition, sharing, and retention of essential capacities,” which also accelerates our progress along both pathways.

There are several assumptions along the two impact pathways. In the first pathway, national policymakers are motivated to change because we believe they have the following attitudes or beliefs.

1. Evidence-based policy support
 - They value CGIAR's evidence and recommendations related to food systems transformation, which motivates them to enact policies and regulations through NAP-FST and other policy processes.
 - They perceive that CGIAR's evidence fills gaps in developing and prioritizing policies for perishable nutrient-rich foods, such as fruits, vegetables, aquatic foods, and terrestrial animal source foods.
2. Feasibility and cost-effectiveness of tested solutions
 - They are convinced of the benefits of tested market solutions to improve food safety and understand that these solutions are cost-effective.
 - They see the value and feasibility of integrating biofortified and health-enhancing crops into national policies, as these can increase consumers' mineral and vitamin intake without additional cost (by substituting them one-for-one for non-biofortified staples).
3. Alignment with broader health and trade strategies
 - Influential individuals within national governments believe that promoting sustainable healthy diets is important and are convinced that trade policy changes (e.g., reducing UPF consumption) will improve the healthiness of diets and health outcomes.

The government actors at national and sub-national levels in that same pathway are motivated to change because:

1. Relevant evidence that helps them to change desirability, affordability, accessibility and consumer agency to improve the consumption of sustainable healthy diets and/or limit the consumption of unhealthy food is available in a timely and usable format.
2. They find an important contribution from sectors not involved in food systems transformation in increasing the consumption of sustainable healthy diets.
3. They see themselves capable to modify programs and they contribute to increasing the consumption of sustainable healthy diets.
4. They believe in creating a shared agenda on sustainable healthy diets along with partners in the climate and biodiversity space.

In the second pathway, food system actors (producers, traders, processors, retailers) are motivated to change because:

1. They are convinced that affordable, increased availability of healthy foods will expand market demand and raise their profits. Enhanced employment opportunities will attract qualified staff and increase their overall profits. Adoption of tested solutions and finance options lead to increased demand (desirability, accessibility?) or allow for increased supply (availability) of healthy foods offered by market system actors.
2. They are interested in developing skills and have financial incentives to engage in and implement end-to-end solutions, which encourages their active participation and commitment.
3. They are aware of, desire, and have access to inputs, and can make profits (faster) from biofortified and health-enhancing crops. They also see value and can implement policy recommendations.

Our approaches, activities, and outputs

The approaches we use in our Program are organized across the entire food system — from consumer to producer.

1. **Consumer-oriented policy strategies.** The objective of this approach is to leverage government policy and public sector tools to shape consumers' food environments, choices, and behaviors toward sustainable healthy diets alongside other development goals like reducing social inequities, reducing poverty, and minimizing negative impacts on the environment. The primary policy entry point in the LMICs where we work is their NAP-FST. This is the primary approach of Consumers and Food Environments (AoW1).

Our planned activities generate evidence to inform, design, and evaluate government-led strategies that influence consumer's food environments, choices, and behaviors toward sustainable healthy diets. Research includes policy landscape analysis, political economy studies, foresight modeling, evidence on consumer behavior and diets of different population groups like adolescents, studies on the effects of food labeling or taxes on consumer behavior and dietary intake, experiments to test the effect nudges or environmental cues have on food choices, and formative research that can be used for other interventions, like public awareness and education. Close engagement with government actors responsible for implementing the NAP-FST provides opportunities for us to provide technical support, co-design training and other capacity sharing activities, co-develop innovative ways to monitor the process of food systems transformation (vs the outcomes), and facilitate south-south exchanges that help government actors learn from other examples of what's working.

Our expected outputs include a suite of solutions targeted at consumers and vendors, co-developed, tested, and scaled with country engagement to promote consumption of sustainable healthy diets and increase employment and sales of nutritious foods. In parallel, we contribute policy options and engagement support for the effective management of NAP-FST and related policy processes.

2. **Market-oriented innovations.** The objective of this approach is to catalyze innovation in food markets and value chains to improve access to sustainable healthy diets, reduce food system inefficiencies, and align commercial incentives with public health and environmental goals. Like in the first approach, the primary policy entry point in the LMICs where we work is their NAP-FST. This is the primary approach of Market Systems (AoW2).

This approach has three specific research angles. First, we want to understand ways to improve market system performance, particularly as it relates to healthy foods. Specifically, we will examine innovative ways to reward aspects of food quality, reduce risks related to food safety, reduce transaction costs between actors in specific value chains, and reduce food loss and waste. While these changes would help increase the availability of healthy foods for consumers, they are not sufficient to grow markets. To help grow availability and increase affordability, we study innovations in finance markets, including insurance. This research will help build an understanding of what types of finance market system actors will adopt, and to help design products for those actors to increase the flow of finance to grow these markets. Third, it is important to understand broader macroeconomic issues that shape food availability for consumers. Areas we will study include regulations shaping availability of ultra-processed foods, and the role of international trade for healthier foods. Throughout our research, we focus on using innovative methods of data collection, and we collaborate with local institutions.

Our expected output includes a suite of tested solutions for farm input dealers, traders, processors, and retailers to improve food quality and safety, reduce food loss, and increase efficiency across value chains. We also generate solutions to expand access to finance for these actors and contribute policy options and engagement supporting domestic food and trade policies—particularly those that address the supply and consumption of ultra-processed foods.

3. **Holistic, integrated actions along the entire value chain** (“end-to-end”) to promote **perishable, nutrient-rich foods** and **biofortified and health-enhancing staples**. The objective of this approach is to transform entire value chains—from production to consumption—to improve the availability, affordability, and desirability of perishable, nutrient-rich foods and biofortified or health-enhancing staples, while reducing food loss and waste and minimizing negative impacts on the environment. This is the primary approach of End-to-End Solutions (AoW3) and Biofortified and Health-Enhancing Staples (AoW4).

Our planned activities generate evidence across the full value chain to improve the efficiency, equity, and effectiveness of producing, processing, distributing, and consuming perishable, nutrient-rich foods and biofortified or health-enhancing staples. Research includes agronomic studies; food loss assessments; studies on the efficacy, affordability, and scalability of low-cost storage, drying, and processing technologies (e.g., solar cold storage, improved packaging); studies on how prices, margins, and consumer demand affect the availability of nutrient-rich foods; willingness-to-pay experiments; and formative research that can be used for other interventions, like public awareness and education; policy analysis; and development of decision tools to help governments and funders prioritize investments in key value chains. For biofortified and health-enhancing staples, activities will include product development. Engagement with roundtables, food system alliances, and other multi-stakeholder platforms will help drive collective action and partnerships provide opportunities for technical support and to co-design training and other capacity sharing activities.

Our expected outputs include a suite of end-to-end solutions tailored to F&V, aquatic, and terrestrial animal-source food value chains, as well as integrated solutions across food producers, traders, processors, and vendors—designed to improve food quality and safety, reduce food loss, and increase profitability. We also generate policy options that address key constraints to sustainable healthy diets. Complementing this, we co-develop and scale solutions that support producers, processors, traders, and vendors in overcoming barriers to biofortified and health-enhancing foods, alongside tools to improve consumer awareness and utilization. Additionally, we advance a framework to embed nutrition into breeding pipelines and product development processes.

Lack of leadership, coordination, institutional capacity, and technical capacity can hinder the successful implementation of any of our approaches. The Program uses all activities described in AoW6 as a feedback mechanism to consolidate evidence, tools and insights at national level and target regional and global platforms and processes such as the Comprehensive African Agricultural Development Program, the Scaling Up Nutrition Movement, the United Nations Climate Change Conference, and the UNFSS to elevate the significance of food system transformation and its linkages to diets, and to influence policy, coordination, and governance for better diets and nutrition in regions, and globally. The feedback mechanism acts internally to CGIAR as well to a) amplify the 2030 outcome through the other programs and b) obtain coherence on how diets and nutrition should advance at portfolio level. This is primarily the responsibility of Transformative Leadership (AoW6).

Certain conditions need to be met for food system and food environment actions to result in healthy diets and thus contribute to better nutritional status. The Program generates evidence on interventions that enhance the positive impact of food system transformation through improving the affordability, accessibility, availability, and desirability of foods that are needed for a sustainable healthy diet.

Geographical Coverage

We apply this logic starting from fifteen countries in Year 1 as result of previous interventions and running research (Bangladesh, Benin, Ethiopia, Ghana, Guatemala, Honduras, India, Kenya, Malawi, Nigeria, the Philippines, Sri Lanka, Tanzania, Uganda, and Viet Nam). We recognize that not all entry points are considered in all countries at the same time and several CGIAR interventions (i.e. bilateral projects) have been defined prior to the starting of our program logic.

- AoW1 focus in 2025: Bangladesh, Ethiopia, Ghana, Guatemala, Honduras, Kenya, Tanzania, and Viet Nam.
- AoW2 focus in 2025: Bangladesh, Ethiopia, Honduras, India, Kenya, Nigeria, and Uganda.
- AoW3 focus in 2025: Benin, the Philippines, Sri Lanka, Tanzania, and Uganda.
- AoW4 focus in 2025: Bangladesh, Ethiopia, Guatemala, India, Kenya, Malawi, Nigeria, the Philippines, and Uganda.

MELIA

We commit to implement Monitoring, Evaluation, Learning, and Impact Assessment (MELIA) studies in the first years to test our overall assumptions and more specifically to learn if all entry points are required at the same time or they can be phased or not included. We are also keen to learn about the value added by bilateral projects not at the level of single result but overall food system. **(These studies will focus on learning about the causal logic of our ToC, assessing how and under what conditions different entry points contribute to systems change, and identifying the synergies or complementarities offered by bilateral initiatives.)**

Partnerships

The success of this Program is anchored in a diverse and strategic set of partnerships that span local, national, regional, and global levels. Across the AoW, these collaborations are essential for designing, implementing, evaluating, and scaling food system solutions tailored to country contexts and population needs.

At the national level, strong partnerships continue with government ministries, departments, or agencies responsible for implementing frameworks such as the NAP-FST. These collaborations ensure alignment with country demands and enable adaptive planning and budgeting.

Implementation agencies—spanning sectors such as health, education, agriculture, social protection, and water and sanitation play a critical role, supported by extension networks and local community-based organizations.

Private-sector engagement is emphasized, particularly with MSMEs and informal actors, who are central to local food environments. Seed companies, suppliers, and food-related businesses are also involved in efficacy and field trials, especially in nutrition and food safety innovation.

On the research front, the program works closely with a range of international and national research institutions, including leading universities in both the Global North and South. These

partnerships contribute technical expertise in key areas such as nutrition, gender equity, environmental sustainability, and climate change.

Collaborative platforms such as AgIncentives and the African Nutrition Leadership Program and the Agriculture, Nutrition, and Health Academy further enhance knowledge exchange and policy engagement.

Contributions of Window 3/bilaterally funded projects

In Years 1-2, we will be able to report results contributing to our 2030-outcome (consumers utilize biofortified and health-enhancing crops and processed products derived from them in their diets). The data will come from five Window 3 (W3)/bilaterally funded projects operating in 10 countries in Africa, South Asia, and Latin America. Lessons learned in those 10 countries can be applied in our work to better understand how such a promising solution like biofortified crops are not reaching or are not being accepted by consumers in LMICs. Also in Years 1-2, many results from the W3/bilateral projects will make significant contributions to outputs across all six AoWs.

At the same time, a subset of the projects already have mechanisms in place in 2025 to work closely with our Program. One example is the Asia-Africa BlueTech Superhighway (AABS) project. The project has a credible pathway for improving diets but does not have an outcome as such, but our involvement will add this lens in Tanzania. The AABS team will conduct studies on climate-smart loss and waste technologies, and we will complement this with studies on nutrition-sensitive trade flows of small pelagic fish, dagaa, to address both the climate and diet challenges. Over time, as the CGIAR System puts mechanisms in place that enable the alignment of the pooled funding and W3/bilaterally funded projects into a single Portfolio, we expect there to be more examples of well-aligned projects like AABS in our Program, contributing results to our theory of change and adding evidence that helps us test our assumptions.

ToC Analysis against CGIAR facilitating questions

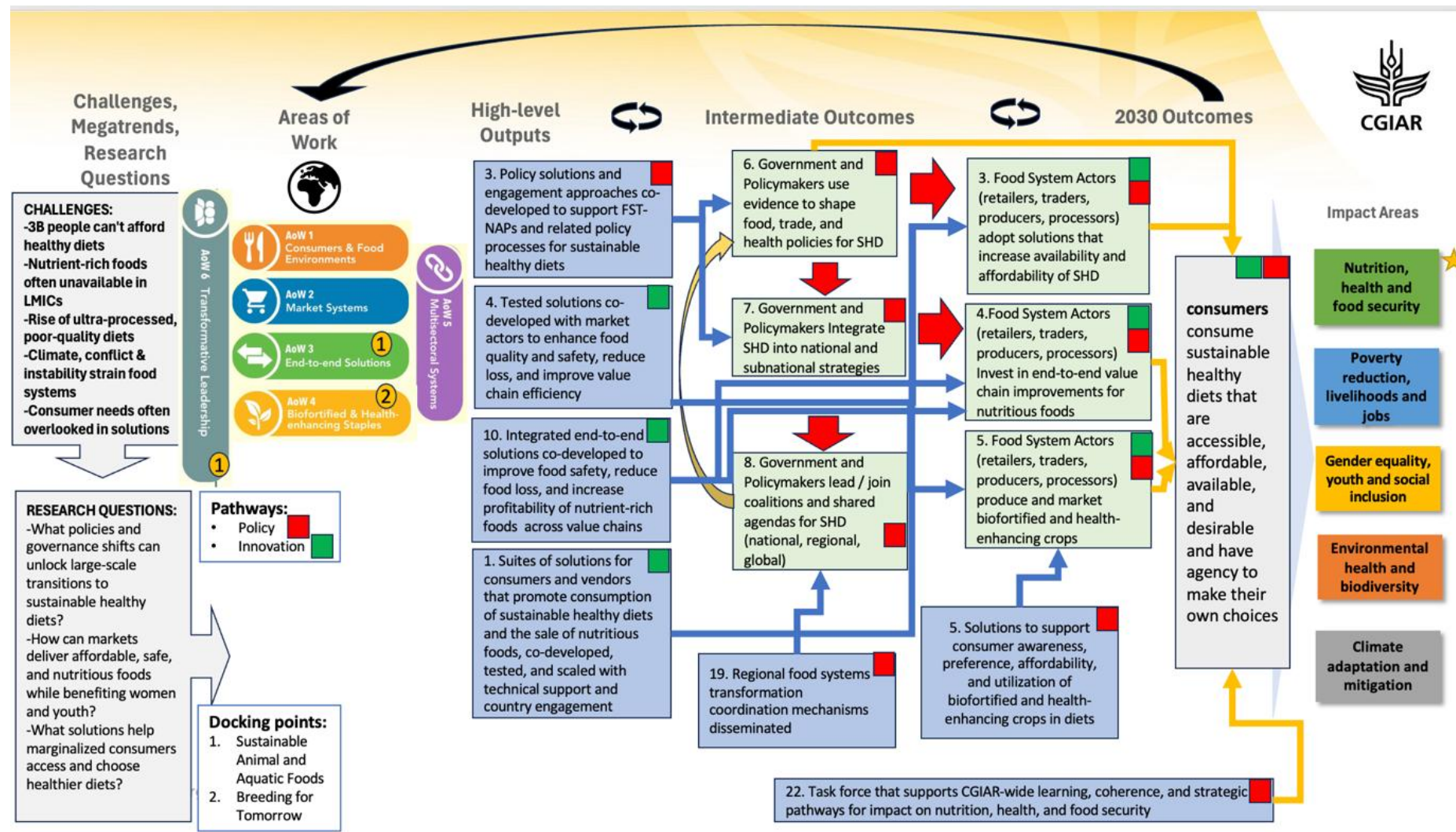
ISDC Comment	Where/How we addressed
It is not clear from the overall Theory of Change as to how the ambitious outcomes will be achieved within the indicated timeframe.	The pathways, intermediate outcomes, and specific outputs are clearly structured under each AoW, showing the steps toward the 2030 outcome. Sections like 'Our approaches, activities, and outputs' and 'expected outcomes before 2030' offer the logic and timeframe.
The underlying assumptions are not explicit and are likely to pose a significant constraint to achievement of outcomes.	See 'There are several assumptions behind this goal' and 'assumptions along the two impact pathways'. These sections lay out the assumptions clearly and explicitly.
Numerous pre-requisites and complementary investments must be in place at country level (e.g., rigorous food control mechanisms and facilities)...	Mentioned under 'Partnerships' and 'Implementation agencies... play a critical role', but the example of food control mechanisms is not explicitly cited.
...to realize the gains from the research.	Embedded throughout sections like 'expected outputs' and 'research includes...' where direct gains from outputs and activities are described.
Also, the geographies for which the overall Theory of Changes are applicable are not clear.	Explicitly addressed in 'Geographical Coverage', with AoW-level breakdowns and country lists.

ISDC Comment	Where/How we addressed
Achieving the High-Level Outcomes relating to population-level dietary change will take most Areas of Work operating synergistically within a country...	Discussed in MELIA section: 'to learn if all entry points are required at the same time...' and explicitly linked to testing AoW integration.
...but many countries have only a couple of AoWs planned (and therefore much rests on successfully catalyzing research from elsewhere).	Also covered in MELIA section; AoW deployment strategy and partnerships underscore cross-learning and scaling.
Consumers appear as passive agents in the Theory of Change even though key outcomes relate to them.	Consumer behavior and agency are central to outcomes and are explicitly addressed in the assumptions, AoW1 activities, and outcomes.
...and climate change aspects are downplayed.	Mentioned in 'climate vulnerability' and in partnerships and assumptions, but not yet fully integrated as a cross-cutting theme or core causal factor.

ToC analysis against ISDC proposal review

ISDC Comment	Where/How we addressed
It is not clear from the overall Theory of Change as to how the ambitious outcomes will be achieved within the indicated timeframe.	The pathways, intermediate outcomes, and specific outputs are clearly structured under each AoW, showing the steps toward the 2030 outcome. Sections like 'Our approaches, activities, and outputs' and 'expected outcomes before 2030' offer the logic and timeframe.
The underlying assumptions are not explicit and are likely to pose a significant constraint to achievement of outcomes.	See 'There are several assumptions behind this goal' and 'assumptions along the two impact pathways'. These sections lay out the assumptions clearly and explicitly.
Numerous pre-requisites and complementary investments must be placed at country level (e.g., rigorous food control mechanisms and facilities)...	Mentioned under 'Partnerships' and 'Implementation agencies... play a critical role', but the example of food control mechanisms is not explicitly cited.
...to realize the gains from the research.	Embedded throughout sections like 'expected outputs' and 'research includes...' where direct gains from outputs and activities are described.
Also, the geographies for which the overall Theory of Changes are applicable are not clear.	Explicitly addressed in 'Geographical Coverage', with AoW-level breakdowns and country lists.
Achieving the High-Level Outcomes relating to population-level dietary change will take most Areas of Work operating synergistically within a country...	Discussed in MELIA section: 'to learn if all entry points are required at the same time...' and explicitly linked to testing AoW integration.
...but many countries have only a couple of AoWs planned (and therefore much rests on successfully catalyzing research from elsewhere).	Also covered in MELIA section; AoW deployment strategy and partnerships underscore cross-learning and scaling.
Consumers appear as passive agents in the Theory of Change even though key outcomes relate to them.	Consumer behavior and agency are central to outcomes and are explicitly addressed in the assumptions, AoW1 activities, and outcomes.
...and climate change aspects are downplayed.	Mentioned in 'climate vulnerability' and in partnerships and assumptions, but not yet fully integrated as a cross-cutting theme or core causal factor.

ToC diagram



Results framework

The program result framework is accessible from the Online ToC Board (Link: <https://toc.mel.cgiar.org/toc/567e4617-92b2-462b-a93c-86e3f4ab3239?relatedFlowId=ca63d124-8943-49fc-bc56-95497ef15191>).

2. Monitoring plan for HLOs and outcomes

This section outlines how Better Diets and Nutrition will monitor the delivery of high-level outputs (HLOs) and progress toward defined outcomes. The monitoring approach reflects the Program's decentralized structure with strong central coordination, ensuring that routine tracking of indicators against the logical framework is feasible, relevant, and aligned with resource availability. Indicators will be reviewed annually and revised as necessary, based on implementation progress, emerging priorities, and feedback from AoW teams and partners.

The Program ToC and results framework **comprises 22 HLOs and 30 outcomes**. The results framework for the program will be submitted through the Performance and Results Management System (PRMS) ToC Board, and exported in Excel format for review, as per guidance.

HLOs represent results such as tools, guidelines, datasets, and tested solutions; outcomes represent the behavioral and systemic changes these outputs are expected to generate.

We will use the CGIAR standard indicators for outputs (innovation development, capacity sharing and knowledge product) to measure progress towards the HLOs and for outcomes, we expect to use primarily the CGIAR standard indicators on policy change and innovation use. For the 2030 outcomes, specific indicators will be used.

Monitoring efforts will be embedded into a results-based management approach, supported by the PRMS reporting platform. Progress will be tracked through regular data collection cycles to contribute to adaptive management and inform reporting outputs. Monitoring data recorded in PRMS will serve as the foundation for compiling evidence in formal reporting, including Annual Technical Reports and dashboard contributions. A periodic export will ensure we can monitor progress against planned targets. Final validation of monitoring data in PRMS will follow CGIAR System Office guidance and will support the Program's reporting cycles.

A dedicated 50% MELIA focal point will focus on outcome actors identification, assumption validation, and outcome monitoring. The program coordinator will ensure that at centralized level all MELIA responsibilities are following SO timeline. Dedicated scientists will instead lead or support the impact assessment work.

The program recognizes the need to prioritize baselines for outcome indicators, as most HLOs will be newly developed and do not require a baseline. Baseline planning and data collection will be sequenced based on funding availability, focusing first on critical indicators related to early outcome targets.

While the bilateral projects contribution and relevant workflow has still to be defined at SO level the program will assess if a) the projects have a monitoring mechanism in place and b) what are the quick wins to collect the most valuable contribution from these projects avoiding duplication of efforts.

Data collection strategy

The Program will rely on a mix of quantitative and qualitative data collection approaches, tailored to the nature of the indicators and operating contexts. The following elements will define the strategy for each indicator:

1. MELIA staff roles and responsibilities

- The 50% MELIA focal point will lead outcome-level indicator tracking, including developing data protocols and liaising with country teams.

- AoW Leaders are responsible for ensuring staff will deliver timely and document HLOs.
- The program coordinator oversees overall MELIA coordination, data input into the PRMS system, quality assurance, and integration into program planning and reporting.
- Technical scientists will support outcome evaluations and impact assessment studies as needed.

2. Frequency of data collection

- Baselines for outcome indicators will be established progressively, prioritizing those linked to Year 1–2 targets.
- Routine data collection will occur annually or biannually depending on the indicator type.
- HLO tracking will occur quarterly to align with internal reporting cycles.

3. Methods and Tools The following data collection methods will be used as appropriate:

- Household surveys (cross-sectional or panel)
- End-user and next-user tracking (individuals and organizations)
- Surveys of organizations
- Market/business surveys
- Modeling
- Structured interviews and focus groups
- Citation analysis
- Other participatory and qualitative tools

4. Quality Checks to Ensure Data Reliability The program will introduce a quality assurance checklist to guide consistent and credible reporting into the PRMS system. Key elements include:

- Use of standardized data collection tools
- Training and calibration of enumerators or field staff
- Spot-checks and validation missions by MELIA or AoW focal points
- Automated consistency checks in digital entry platforms (if used during the program implementation)
- Clear metadata documentation for each indicator
- Peer review or AoW lead/Director sign-off before data submission (especially at outcome level)

5. Contingency Plan for Data Collection Risks To address potential disruptions, the program will maintain a risk mitigation table that is regularly updated. Initial measures include:

Risk	Potential Impact	Mitigation Strategy
Budget constraints	Incomplete data or skipped cycles	Prioritize key outcome indicators; stagger baseline work
Staff turnover	Loss of institutional knowledge	Maintain detailed protocols; cross-train MELIA team
Low data quality or inconsistency	Unreliable results	Implement QA checklist; conduct regular audits

This monitoring plan will evolve based on implementation experience and feedback from AoW leaders, partners, as part of the learning and adaptive management process. Data and insights will be used not only for accountability but also for adaptive management and strategic decision-making within the program.

3. Evaluation plan

Evaluation is relevant for Program accountability, reflection, and adaptive management. While impact assessments target the longer-term and causal effects of our activities, evaluations help assess the quality and effectiveness of ongoing strategies, implementation mechanisms, and internal coherence. The Program will align with the CGIAR Evaluation Policy, consulting the Independent Advisory and Evaluation Service (IAES) as needed for methodological support and coordination.

Evaluation studies

At this stage, the Program has identified five areas where targeted evaluations could add substantial value. These will be refined over time based on learning needs, implementation maturity, and resource availability:

- 1. Actor Engagement and Assumption Validation** (Type: Qualitative outcome study)
This evaluation will document the specific stakeholders (individuals, institutions, or networks) that AoW teams are targeting under each outcome pathway, going beyond the generic categories listed in the ToC (e.g., “policy actors” or “producers”). Once real actors are confirmed, the evaluation will assess whether the assumptions regarding their incentives, behaviors, and capacities—embedded in the current ToC—are realistic and supported by evidence. Findings will inform revisions to outcome pathways and critical assumptions during the next ToC update cycle.
- 2. Strategic Coherence Across Geographies** (Type: Program/project evaluation)
This evaluation will examine whether expected outcomes—particularly those involving consumer-level dietary change—can be achieved in countries with limited AoW presence. It will explore whether a minimal AoW footprint is sufficient, or whether broader presence is required to deliver systemic outcomes.
- 3. Configuration and Integration of AoWs** (Type: Program/project evaluation)
Building on operational observations, this evaluation will assess whether AoW2 and AoW3 are optimally structured and positioned to contribute to shared outcomes. It will explore whether reconfiguration or deeper integration could enhance outcome delivery and reduce fragmentation.
- 4. Value Addition of W3/Bilateral Projects** (Type: Program/project evaluation)
This evaluation will examine the extent to which W3/bilateral projects align with and contribute to program-level HLOs and outcomes. It will assess whether these projects introduce innovations or partnerships that can be scaled through the core program, or whether integration challenges persist.
- 5. Internal Learning and Use of MELIA Results** (Type: Other MELIA activity – focused on adaptive management and learning use)
This evaluation will focus on how MELIA findings—especially from studies and monitoring efforts—are being used for decision-making at AoW and program levels. It will assess the enabling and limiting factors for evidence uptake across teams.
- 6. Portfolio-Level Nutrition Contribution** (Type: Program/project evaluation)
This evaluation will assess how the CGIAR Portfolio, including Better Diets and Nutrition and related P/A, contributes to system-wide IA on Nutrition targets. It will also explore how synergies or duplication arise across programs and identify areas for collective learning. Findings will inform CGIAR-level ToC for the IA on Nutrition

Key Evaluation Questions

Some guiding questions that will inform future evaluations include:

- Are the Program's assumptions about actor behavior, incentives, and influence valid for the specific stakeholders identified, and are they likely to lead to the intended outcomes?
- How do differences in AoW presence across countries affect the Program's ability to deliver its intended outcomes?
- Are the current configurations of AoWs efficient and synergistic, or are there opportunities to increase impact through structural changes?
- What mechanisms exist (or are lacking) to integrate bilateral and W3-funded results into core program planning and reporting?
- To what extent is MELIA evidence used to inform planning, learning, and adaptation across the Program?
- How well do program assumptions and outcome pathways reflect national priorities and systems capacities in each geography?
- • What types of MELIA findings (e.g., indicators, case studies, behavioral data) are most useful to decision-makers, and how can their use be institutionalized?

These questions will be further refined based on evidence, and as the implementation context evolves.

Timeline

The Program envisions launching one or two evaluation exercises in 2025 giving priorities to the validation of ToC assumptions (#1) and assessing the ToC structure (#3). This will allow for meaningful evaluation of processes, actor engagement, and structural alignment. Evaluations will be timed to feed into the next ToC revision cycle and program reprioritization discussions.

Evaluation collaboration plans

While the Program has proactively reached out to all CGIAR Programs and Accelerators to inquire about their nutrition-related outcomes, no concrete opportunities for joint evaluation have yet arisen. However, we have engaged in discussions with Multifunctional Landscapes to explore similarities between Better Diets and Nutrition and their pathway from Multifunctional Landscapes' HLO 1.5: Nutrition-enhancing innovations bundled to ensure availability, desirability, and affordability for diverse populations to their 2030 Outcome: Landscape stakeholders apply technological, socio-ecological, policy and/or institutional innovations that enhance food production, ecosystem restoration and gains, biodiversity conservation and protection, social cohesion and resilience, and healthy diets in thriving Multifunctional Landscapes.

A similar exchange took place with Sustainable Animal and Aquatic Foods, focusing on their 2030 Outcome: Animal and aquatic food producers and their households integrate adequate, safe, nutrient-dense animal and aquatic foods in diverse diets.

It is anticipated that additional collaboration may come once MELIA plans are finalized and shared. The Program remains open to co-designing evaluations—particularly around shared assumptions, geographies, or thematic focus areas.

Similarly, while titles and expected results of W3/bilateral projects mapped to the Program are available, these do not yet include formal evaluation components. As part of the 2025–2026 planning cycle, the Program will engage with project teams to explore opportunities for embedded evaluations.

Going forward, the Program will continue to coordinate with IAES for alignment with CGIAR-wide evaluation priorities and will actively explore funding or collaboration opportunities.

4. Impact assessment

The Program's collective contribution to 2030 outcomes and impact is organized through two interconnected pathways: innovation and policy accelerated by capacity sharing. These pathways aim to influence the behavior of government actors, market system actors, and policy communities to improve the accessibility, affordability, availability, and desirability of sustainable healthy diets and consumer agency. The pathways also address institutional capacity, the enabling environment, and multisectoral collaboration.

By 2030, the Program expects to demonstrate outcomes such as improved dietary diversity, cost reductions for healthy diets, and inclusive food systems transformation. Priority indicators for impact include the MDD for Women (MDD-W), the Cost of a Healthy Diet, and nutrition-sensitive policy uptake. These indicators are aligned with CGIAR Portfolio-level outcomes and SDG 2 and 3 targets.

The updated ToC explicitly identifies critical assumptions about actor behavior, incentive structures, and pathway synergies that will be tested through impact assessments. Key assumptions include the cost effectiveness of tested innovations, and therefore their scalability; policy alignment with sustainable healthy diet goals; and the absorptive capacity of local systems.

Impact assessment activities and collaboration plans

Better Diets and Nutrition adopts a strategic two-pronged approach to impact assessment, combining rigorous evaluation methods with broader integrative studies. Impact assessment supports ToC validation and understanding how innovations translate into system-wide change and tangible benefits.

The Program will use *ex ante* and *ex post* impact assessments, alongside scenario analysis, to support prioritization. Where possible, we will design *ex ante* impact assessments with randomization to support causal inference from those interventions. We will also conduct *ex post* impact assessment, which will focus on evidence of causal effects of selected interventions after implementation when *ex ante* evaluations are not possible. *Ex post* studies will be particularly relevant for mature outputs or innovations already adopted or scaled in selected geographies.

Methods will include randomized controlled trials (RCTs), mixed-methods evaluations, and contribution analysis. Collaboration with the Standing Panel on Impact Assessment will be pursued to strengthen methodological rigor and leverage shared tools. Collaborations are foreseen with:

- **Scaling for Impact Program:** to design and assess multisectoral innovations and value-chain interventions.
- **Policy Innovations Program:** to assess institutional and policy changes and test political economy dimensions.
- **Gender Equality and Inclusion Accelerator:** to embed gender-sensitive metrics in impact assessment designs.

- **Bilateral/W3-funded projects:** to identify embedded impact assessment opportunities and avoid duplication.
- **CGIAR IA teams:** to contribute to portfolio-level meta-evaluation and harmonize data with common CGIAR indicators.

Priority will be given to impact in **integrative countries**, where multiple AoWs operate. These broader IA studies will assess the synergies between interventions and provide system-level insights into the pathways driving impact. Potential integrative countries include Bangladesh, Ethiopia, Nigeria, and Tanzania, based on portfolio density and MELIA feasibility.

A senior Impact Specialist will guide study design and implementation, ensure alignment with the CGIAR results framework indicators, and coordinate data quality assurance across IA efforts.

Impact assessment studies

The Program has identified initial IA study themes for inclusion in the MELIA studies. However, these initial themes are not included in the template (Annex 2) due to budget reductions and the limitation to 2025 activities.

The themes identified are:

- Evaluation of policy and institutional innovations for sustainable healthy diets
- Cost-effectiveness and adoption of dietary advisory tools
- RCTs on nutrient-rich foods based on value chains and the food environment

Further prioritization and refinement will occur as the implementation phase progresses and results from early monitoring and MELIA studies inform IA design.

5. Learning and adaptive management

To strengthen internal learning and inform adaptive management, Better Diets and Nutrition will implement MELIA studies during 2025. These studies are designed to generate evidence that tests assumptions in our ToC, identify actors, and contribute to overall strategic alignment within the Program. The findings will feed into the annual review and adaptive planning to ensure that programming decisions are evidence-based and aligned with outcome expectations.

Actor Identification and Assumption Validation

The first study will focus on identifying the specific actors each AoW intends to influence, moving beyond generic categories such as “producers” or “policy actors.” It will also test key behavioral and system-level assumptions embedded in the ToC. The study will be based on existing stakeholder mapping complemented by key informant interviews face to face or virtually across selected countries. Findings will be shared with AoW leaders to validate or revise their outcome pathways—including the associated HLOs—and to guide refinements during the 2026 planning cycle.

Geographic Feasibility and Strategic Coherence

Another priority study will examine the feasibility of achieving consumer-level outcomes in countries where only one or two AoWs are active. This will assess whether all AoWs are needed to support outcome-level change (as commented by ISDC), or whether specific pathways can be achieved by AoWs individually. Findings will be shared with program leadership to support geographic prioritization ensuring greater coherence.

AoW Integration and ToC Optimization

We will assess whether the current configuration of AoW operations—especially AoW2 and AoW3—can be optimized to contribute to shared outcomes. This analysis will draw on field-level implementation in selected countries (e.g., Bangladesh, Benin, Ethiopia, Ghana, Honduras, Kenya, Nigeria, Tanzania, or Uganda). Recommendations will be brought to the attention of program leadership to inform ToC adjustments in 2026.

Value Addition of the W3/Bilateral Projects

In countries where bilateral projects are active, we will assess whether and how these projects contribute to program-level HLOs and outcomes. The study will identify quick wins for integration and propose mechanisms to avoid duplication of monitoring efforts. Findings will support portfolio management decisions and help shape the design of future bilateral engagements.

Portfolio-Level Nutrition Contribution

Lastly, we will conduct a portfolio-level review of how the CGIAR Portfolio contributes to the Nutrition Impact Area Targets, with a focus on identifying gaps and misalignments across programs. This review will not be country-specific and will rely on targeted interviews with global and regional program teams. Findings will contribute to cross-program learning and inform strategic discussions with CGIAR Programs/Accelerators working on nutrition to deliver a CGIAR Level TOC on Nutrition.

Integration into Management Processes

Each study will be designed to generate preliminary insights in time for the annual review meeting. Emerging lessons will be synthesized and shared with the Program Management Team. AoW-specific findings will also be fed back to AoW leaders and relevant team members to enable timely learning loops. Where appropriate, key recommendations will inform MELIA planning for 2026 and the upcoming ToC review cycle.

Annual review and adaptive planning

Better Diets and Nutrition embeds a structured review and adaptive planning cycle into its annual planning and reporting, ensuring continuous learning and adaptive management across its AoWs. This approach is based on the 2022–2024 experience from three incoming Initiatives, FRESH, SHiFT, and Rethinking Food Markets and the Nutrition Impact Platform. Our past experience has proven to be effective at stimulating learning and adaptive management, so we will rely on those processes with an openness to incorporating additional guidance that the CGIAR System Office may provide.

We will use the reflect process to revise our work plans, budgets, risk registers, and ToC elements in light of implementation experiences, contextual shifts, and partner feedback. We will meet at the beginning of each year and involve the Program’s core team—including the Director, the AoW Leads, and members of the Program Management Unit (PMU)—alongside the Country Coordinators, partners, and scientific leads.

We will primarily focus on:

- Progress toward HLOs and Outcomes
- Unmet deliverables and critical lessons learned
- Emerging research opportunities or evidence gaps
- Adjustments required for budget, staffing, or geographic coverage

This ensures that the learnings and recommendations will support the program to deliver revised documents:

- Plan of Results and Budget (PORB)
- People Plan (including staff roles and time allocations)

- Risk Register
- Theory of Change (including indicators, targets, outputs, outcomes)

The process will enable us to **reprioritize HLOs or outcomes** if needed, based on resource availability and evolving country needs. Adjustments may include updating technical content (e.g., adding/removing HLOs or refining outcomes), financial reallocations across area of work or partners.

The Program will use the CGIAR System Office’s online tools, the PRMS and the TOC board, to enact changes and ensure alignment across reporting, planning, and budgeting. The TOC Change Log will be used to document all refinements to outcomes and outputs. Any significant changes affecting contributions to the CGIAR Impact Area indicators or SDG alignment will be reviewed with the appropriate focal points.

6. Reporting

Reporting is part of our results-based management approach. It packages monitoring data, MELIA evidence, and implementation into outputs that support learning, accountability, and decision-making. Reporting ensures that stakeholders — from funders to implementing teams — receive timely, relevant, and credible information on the Program’s performance, challenges, and contributions.

Purpose and Strategic Role

Reporting serves multiple interlinked functions:

- **Strategic management** by feeding evidence into annual reviews, supporting planning and prioritization.
- **Organizational learning** by synthesizing emerging results and lessons.
- **Accountability and transparency** to funders and system actors, aligning with CGIAR’s Technical Reporting Arrangement (TRA).
- **Coherence across funding streams** by linking W1/W2 and W3/bilateral contributions to shared outcomes through a unified ToC-based results architecture.

Evidence Integration and Data Sources

Reporting draws upon multiple evidence sources, each tracked through the PRMS system and reviewed for quality assurance. These include:

- Routine monitoring data of reported results that contribute to the HLO and outcome indicators
- MELIA studies validating assumptions, actor pathways, and feasibility
- Bilateral and W3-funded activity contributions mapped to the ToC

All contributions are tagged with appropriate metadata, in line with CGIAR’s findability, accessibility, interoperability, and reusability (FAIR) data principles, and are uploaded into the PRMS reporting module for synthesis.

Quality Assurance and Reporting Standards

To ensure reliability, the Program will:

- Comply with CGIAR’s quality assurance process for reported results in PRMS
- Participate in periodic webinars to improve reporting quality and reduce reporting burden
- Align narrative synthesis with ToC logic.

Using Reports for Adaptive Management

All reporting products will be systematically reviewed by the leadership team to extract actionable insights. Findings will be presented at annual program management meetings. Recommendations from these reviews will inform:

- Prioritization of AoW efforts in each geography
- Revisions to the ToC during program re-alignment cycles
- Refinement of outcome targets and indicator frameworks
- Funding allocation and bilateral engagement strategies

7. MELIA resources

MELIA budget and staff

Better Diets and Nutrition has developed a MELIA approach that is proportionate, strategic, and embedded across its implementation structure. Effective monitoring, evaluation, learning, and impact assessment are essential to delivering results, learning from evidence, and strengthening accountability across the portfolio.

MELIA Budget and Allocation Strategy

MELIA resource needs for 2025 have been allocated to routine performance tracking, targeted learning, and periodic assessment activities. Given constrained funding, the Program has prioritized investments in:

- Establishing baselines and regular monitoring of outcome indicators
- Light-touch, routine output tracking integrated into the PRMS system
- Targeted MELIA studies focused on key Areas of Work and cross-cutting themes
- Selective contributions to CGIAR-wide impact case studies

Aggregated MELIA costs have been compiled and reported using the Annex 3 budget and staff tables. These estimates are also reflected in the cross-cutting and Area of Work sections of the Program's Plan of Results and Budget (PORB), ensuring consistency between the MELIA Plan and overall financial planning. MELIA allocations will be reviewed and adjusted annually as part of the "Annual review and adaptive planning" cycle.

MELIA Staffing Model

The Program employs a lean but integrated MELIA structure, combining central coordination with distributed responsibilities across Areas of Work:

- A **50% MELIA focal point** is responsible for outcome-level indicator tracking, methodological guidance, delivery of MELIA studies, and liaison with CGIAR-level MELIA functions.
- The **Program Coordinator** oversees integration of MELIA into strategic and operational planning and ensures the quality and coherence of reporting.
- **Six AoW Leads** are accountable for reporting results that contribute to their HLOs, helping the Program to document progress, supported by decentralized data collection efforts.
- **Selected scientists** will contribute to outcome validation and lead or support the design and implementation of impact assessments.

This decentralized yet coordinated structure fosters ownership of MELIA responsibilities across program levels while maintaining consistency and quality.

Looking Ahead

As PRMS tools and global guidance evolve, the Program will explore opportunities to streamline MELIA operations, improve data flow efficiency, and reduce reporting burdens on AoW teams through automation. We plan to engage with the CGIAR MELIAF grant and strongly encourage scientists involved in *ex ante* impact assessments to use measurement concepts developed by the grant team. The Program will also actively engage in capacity-strengthening initiatives and cross-initiative learning processes facilitated by MELCOP.

8. Data management

General approach

Better Diets and Nutrition is committed to responsible, open, and FAIR data management. Data will not be managed by the Program directly but by the CGIAR Centers implementing the activities. All CGIAR Centers endorsed the **CGIAR Open and FAIR Data Assets Policy**, adhering to principles of FAIR, while safeguarding personal and sensitive information.

Types of data and data sources

The Program will generate and use multiple categories of data assets, including:

- Quantitative and qualitative datasets from individual, household, market, organizational, and other types of surveys and interviews
- Monitoring data from HLO and outcome indicators (collected via PRMS)
- Research outputs such as models, software code, and dashboards
- Citation and bibliometric data for evidence tracking

All data assets will be stored in accordance to the policy and following each CGIAR Center's procedures. Data will be accompanied by rich metadata and published in relevant repositories (e.g. The Dataverse Project).

Data collection and storage

Data will be collected through standardized, ethically approved tools that comply with CGIAR's Research Ethics Code and data protection principles. Wherever possible, digital tools and interoperable formats will be used to facilitate data quality and integration. Key repositories and platforms include:

- **CGIAR institutional repositories** (e.g., The Dataverse Project)
- **PRMS** for indicator data and reporting
- **Open-source or national platforms** where data-sharing agreements permit

Datasets will be stored with appropriate documentation and metadata, including versioning, and licensing information.

Open access and FAIR compliance

All data assets will be made as **open as possible**, and FAIR. Specifically:

- Datasets will be deposited in open, stable repositories within **12 months** of data collection or **6 months** of associated publication (whichever is sooner).
- Metadata will be uploaded even in cases of restricted datasets, in line with policy requirements.
- Creative Commons licenses (e.g., CC BY or CC0) will be applied as default, unless ethical or legal constraints require exceptions.

The Program will apply embargo periods only in justified cases and will document such instances according to CGIAR guidance.

Privacy and responsible management

Any data containing **personally identifiable information** or sensitive content will be handled with strict confidentiality, and managed according to:

- Informed consent protocols
- National and international data protection regulations
- Restricted access and secure storage mechanisms
- Clear protocols for data anonymization and access requests

Implementation and oversight

Data management responsibilities will be integrated into research staff roles with the ultimate responsibility being the CGIAR Center conducting the data collection activity. A **data management plan** will be recommended for each major data-generating activity, identifying storage, access, and sharing procedures. The Program will monitor adherence to data policies through periodic reviews and updates.

Annex 2. MELIA studies

The MELIA studies are included as a separate tab in the program results framework accessible from the online ToC Board (<https://toc.mel.cgiar.org/toc/567e4617-92b2-462b-a93c-86e3f4ab3239?relatedFlowId=ca63d124-8943-49fc-bc56-95497ef15191>)

Annex 3. MELIA budget (2025)

Activity title	Activity description	Staff (# per type)	Full-time equivalent (# days)	Staff cost (USD)	Inputs <i>i.e. travel costs, special equipment costs</i>	Inputs cost (USD)	Total cost (USD)
Monitoring activities: Cross-cutting							
<i>Activities related to the routine monitoring of HLOs and outcomes</i>							
Inception meeting (incl. TOC review and prioritization)	The workshop gathered leadership, AoW leads and centers to discuss: Prioritization analysis, comparative advantage analysis, partnership arrangements, Updated ToC, MELIA plan. Location Ethiopia	NA	NA	NA	Logistic costs	75,0000	75,000
		NA	NA	NA			
Annual review and adaptive planning	See description in the Learning section. We may organize it virtually in 2025 or F2F in 2026.	NA	NA	NA	NA	0	0
MELIA Focal point	See official TOR for MELIA FP	#, 1	77.54	900	NA	0	69,794
MELIA studies: Cross-cutting							
<i>MELIA studies to evidence the achievement of program-level impacts and outcomes</i>							
Actor Engagement and Assumption Validation	See description in the evaluation section.	#, 1	10	900	Logistic costs	3,000	12,000
Strategic Coherence Across Geographies	See description in the evaluation section.	#, 1	5	900	Logistic costs	5,000	9,500
AoW Configuration and Integration	See description in the evaluation section.	#, 1	10	900	Logistic costs	5,000	14,000
Value Addition of Bilateral and W3-Funded Projects	See description in the evaluation section.	#, 1	5	900	N/A	0	4,500
Use of MELIA Findings for Learning and Adaptation	See description in the evaluation section.	#, 1	5	900	N/A	0	4,500
Portfolio-Level Nutrition Contribution	See description in the evaluation section.	#, 1	10	900	N/A	0	9,000

Activity title	Activity description	Staff (# per type)	Full-time equivalent (# days)	Staff cost (USD)	Inputs <i>i.e. travel costs, special equipment costs</i>	Inputs cost (USD)	Total cost (USD)
MELIA studies: AoW outcomes <i>MELIA studies to evidence the achievement of AoW-level intermediate outcomes not covered by any cross-cutting MELIA studies</i>							
Total MELIA activity costs							

Next steps: Use the total cost column for each year to fill in the **MELIA Budget: Total Cost** table below.